

LINC

LIVING IN CHRIST

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YOUTH CONNECTING FAITH AND LIFE

THE ART OF FAITH

Arts for the Soul

It's everywhere—sidewalks, social media feeds, neighborhood balconies and streets, TV, and internet. It's not the virus; it's art. People of all ages around the world are creating sidewalk art; giving free concerts on social media; spontaneously playing music from balconies and on empty streets; and enjoying replays on TV and the internet of famous ballets, operas, and Broadway musicals. All of this is in an effort to uplift spirits and connect people during a time of physical distancing.

Woven Through Life and Faith

Anthropologists have long known the importance of art in cultures. From vases skillfully crafted to contain oils for cooking, to highly stylized weaponry using metalworks, to intricate mosaics to adorn places of worship, to ancient pictographs to tell stories, and to monuments to house spirits of the dead—all cultures have woven forms of art into their daily living and annual festivals. The use of religious song, dance, and other arts are prevalent in all ancient texts, including the Christian Bible. The Bible refers to early altars of stone for worship, includes books of poetry and songs, recounts the materials and artistry used to adorn the temple in Jerusalem, and describes the incredible beauty of John's vision of heaven.

Exhibition

Like faith, art can be healing. Whether we write, paint, create music, do photography, dance, sew, design buildings or interiors, or do any other type of art, we are expressing parts of ourselves. During a time of physical distancing, we still can connect powerfully with God and with one another. We can share prayer time, our emotions, our creativity, and our love for one another and the world. Putting our own creativity into the world will look different for everyone. But our poetry, music, dance, prose, paintings, mosaics, collages (or any art forms we choose) are not only therapeutic for us, but also can inspire others.



TIP FOR THIS ISSUE

Consider using Zoom or a similar platform with screen sharing for your meeting so that you can share websites and/or images in real time with your class. (Be sure to use a meeting password, host-only screen sharing, and lock the meeting after everyone arrives.) Not everyone is artistic or musical, but everyone is creative in her or his own God-given ways. Affirm all types of creativity and artistic expression. Remind teens that enjoying a variety of art forms during this time can be relaxing, comforting, inspiring, and even healing.

TEACHER BIBLE PREP

ARTISTS IN (FORCED) RESIDENCE

Question of the Day: How has your appreciation for, or participation in, the arts changed during physical distancing or quarantine?

Purpose: To help teens find hope and inspiration in the arts during physical distancing or isolation

Cultural Connection: Explosion of artists sharing via social media during quarantine to uplift spirits

Topic: Role of Arts in Society and Religion

ARCHITECTS OF ART

Genesis 28:10-22

This stone that I've set up as a sacred pillar will be God's house, and of everything you give me I will give a tenth back to you. —Genesis 28:22

Commentary:

Jacob met God in a dream and set up the stone he had used as a pillow to signify that place as holy ground. Jacob wanted to remember the place for the covenant God made with him and his descendants. Placing stones to commemorate a significant event or memorial was a precursor to temples and monuments. Archaeologists categorize these as sites for activity created by art. The monument, memorial, or depiction calls for re-enactment, recalling or sharing specific memories, or ceremonies or commemoration.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ What covenant did God make with Jacob?
- ▶ Why was it so important for Jacob to commemorate or mark that place?
- ▶ What did the stone or sacred pillar symbolize?
- ▶ Do we have modern places in our world that symbolize activity of God?
- ▶ How can monuments or memorials inspire us?



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A LITTLE SONG AND DANCE

Psalms 96

Sing to the LORD a new song! Sing to the LORD, all the earth!

—Psalm 96:1

Commentary:

The Book of Psalms is a collection of poems and music used to express human emotions within the godly relationship. David was a musician and was believed to have created many songs for worshipping God and retelling the stories of Israel. The creative use of music and language combined produces the most powerful form of communication. This is a reason the church has used psalms and music to share the Scripture and faith since its inception. Perhaps the song most known and loved by Christians of all ages is “Jesus Loves Me,” because it speaks of both biblical and personal truth. Art forms such as music, dance, theater, and even preaching are known as performance or participatory art.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ What is the point of this psalm? What is it communicating?
- ▶ What are your favorite worship songs? What do they communicate?
- ▶ Do you have a favorite Bible story or verse? Has it been set to music or used in a song?
- ▶ How do different arts enhance worship? faith in general?
- ▶ How do arts make life in general better?

TEACHER BIBLE PREP

FROM A DISTANCE

Luke 17:11-19

As he entered a village, ten men with skin diseases approached him. Keeping their distance from him, they raised their voices and said, "Jesus, Master, show us mercy!" —Luke 17:12-13

Commentary:

Ancient cultures practiced social distancing long before this global pandemic. Those with illnesses or diseases were sent far away to live in colonies of other sick people or in isolation. They were outcast, shamed, and left to fend for themselves, unable to return to society unless a priest declared them clean. The Gospel of Luke reports this miraculous healing from a distance. Without seeing Jesus up close, the men had faith in who Jesus was and how his power could help them. Without touching them, Jesus healed them from a distance and sent them to a priest so that they could rejoin society.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ What does this story tell you about Jesus' power?
- ▶ In what ways do you feel distant from others right now (aside from physically)?
- ▶ Do you ever feel distant from God? Do you think distance can affect God's power?
- ▶ Even though many of us are connecting via technology, some are still feeling socially distant or isolated. Is there any way to overcome this?
- ▶ How can creative time help you feel connected to God? to find hope? to be inspired?

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DEVOTION: DRAWING ON OUR FAITH

Recall the story of Jesus and the adulterous woman. Read John 8:1-11 slowly and consider what significance, if any, can be made of Jesus writing on the ground instead of engaging in conversation. Is a written word more powerful than a spoken word? Is an image more powerful than words? We do not know what Jesus wrote on the ground. We do know that the combination of what he wrote and said caused the Pharisees to back down and walk away. When has an image or written word changed your mind or heart about something? What faith symbols are most



powerful to you? How might you share your faith with someone without speaking, but by drawing symbols? Consider creating a collage of faith symbols and words that represents your faith at this moment in time. Think about asking teens to make a faith collage this week, and figure out how you might share them during or after class.

NEXT WEEK: We've all had to make sacrifices as the weeks have passed. Next week in *LinC* we'll take a moment to consider those whose careers cause them to sacrifice their personal safety for the benefit of many.

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Writer: Melissa Slocum

Editor: Kevin Alton

Production Editor: Heidi Hewitt

Template Designer: Micah Kandros

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Getting Ready: Arrange a day and time for your group to video conference and, if possible, send the link a few days prior to the meeting. Suggest students read all the Scripture passages and gather the following items before your video call begins: a Bible or Bible app, paper, pens or pencils, colored pencils, crayons or markers, any musical instruments they have. Email Youth Page 6 ahead of time to students, or be ready to show the page on your video screen. Also email them a link to a coloring book page (such as <https://static1.squarespace.com/static/5511fc7ce4b0a3782aa9418b/t/5e97579919a3067f978ef9ab/1586976665965/we-are-all-in-this-together-coloring-page-by-Thaneeya-McArdle-1.jpg>), and ask them to color it before the meeting.

OPEN

Coloring the World (10 minutes)

Greet and welcome everyone, and ask if anyone had time to color the coloring page you sent earlier in the week. If so, invite teens to share their coloring page by holding it in front of the camera. If not, invite teens to color it now while still paying attention. Check in and ask how everyone is doing. (As a prompt, ask what color best represents their emotion/mood right now.) This is a great time to affirm that everyone is dealing with things differently and that you are all together to help support one another. Use the Question of the Day and the information on Page 1 to introduce today's topic of art and faith. Share the following link for more coloring resources for teens who want to color: <https://www.thequarantinecoloringbook.com>.

EXPLORE

Talk Topic 1: Divine Art (15 minutes)

Middle School Option

Ask: "How might monuments and memorials be considered works of art? What are some examples? How

have forms of art been used in temples, synagogues, and churches? How do the arts help us worship?"

Invite teens to open their Bible or Bible app to Genesis 28:10-22, and ask a volunteer to read aloud. Use the commentary and questions in the Teacher Bible Prep to lead a discussion about art and architecture in religion. If you can screen share, have the following page open on your laptop and look together at the examples of religious architecture at <https://www.onlineschoolscenter.com/25-impressive-examples-religious-architecture>. (Or you can send the link before or after class.)

High School Option

If you are using Zoom and can screen share, pull up the following website to share while you discuss the role of art in architecture or religion: <https://www.onlineschoolscenter.com/25-impressive-examples-religious-architecture>. Ask: "Why do you think artistic elements have been part of religious architecture? If your place of worship was itself a work of art, would you feel differently inside it? Would it distract from worship, or would it enhance it?"

Invite teens to open their Bible or Bible app to Genesis 28:10-22, and ask a volunteer to read aloud. Use the commentary and questions in Teacher Bible Prep to lead a discussion about art and architecture in religion.

BONUS SMALL GROUP DISCUSSION

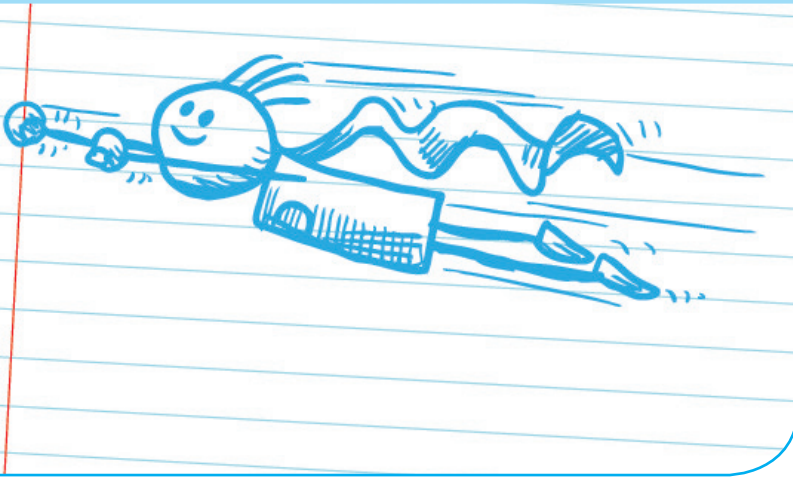
Ask: "All religions have a wealth of religious images and icons created from all types of materials. How does Scripture inspire art? How can art inspire new insights into Scripture?" Encourage teens to use their devices to do a quick search for images of religious art or icons. Ask: "What do you see, and what does that tell you about the importance of art in faith?"

Talk Topic 2: Create a New Song (20 minutes)

Middle School Option

Invite teens to open their Bible or Bible app to Psalm 96 and to take turns reading aloud. Use the commentary and questions in Teacher Bible Prep to talk about the arts in worship. Next, invite teens to collaborate and turn Psalm 96 into a modern worship song. Invite them to use the space on Youth Page 6 to rewrite the lyrics. If they have instruments, you could assign each teen a different section to work on (in a major key, like C) to come up with a melody or chord progression. Even if they get only as far as creating a chorus, that is enough. If your class is not musically inclined, just





rewriting the words as lyrics is a great artistic endeavor. If you run out of time to finish the song, ask for a volunteer to continue working on it and share it with the class next week. Ask: “How does it feel to work together on something creative?”

High School Option

Consider using the Middle School activity outlined above. Or invite teens to open their Bible or Bible app and take turns reading parts of Psalm 96 out loud. Use the commentary and questions in Teacher Bible Prep to talk about the arts in worship. Ask: “How many types of art are used in worship? How many can we name? As a class, how could we re-create Psalm 96?” Take several minutes to use one or more of their ideas combined to create a new song, a collage, a poem, or any other creation they choose based on Psalm 96. Have them use the space on Youth Page 6 as needed.

Talk Topic 3: Drawing Hope from Art (15 minutes)

Middle School Option

Invite teens to have handy paper and things to draw and color with. Say: “We’re going to draw ourselves as superheroes. Think about what special power you have or would like to have. What type of superhero costume would you like to wear? Would you have a mask? What colors would your costume be?” Encourage teens to draw and color anything that represents themselves as a superhero (even if it is just a stick figure). After several minutes, invite teens to take turns holding their drawing up to the camera and explaining briefly what their superhero power is and why they chose it. Encourage them to finish their drawing later, but for now remind them that they are like superheroes during this time. Explain that it takes a lot to change our behaviors, routines, methods of learning, communication, and so forth.

Ask teens to open their Bible or Bible app to Luke 17:11-19 and to read silently. Use the questions and commentary in Teacher Bible Prep to discuss how powerful Jesus was then and is today. Encourage teens to draw hope during this time from the arts and to express themselves and their emotions or thoughts in a variety of ways. Share the following link/page so that teens can continue to get ideas for

expressing themselves creatively: <https://www.expressiveartworkshops.com/expressive-art-resources/100-art-therapy-exercises>.

Close with prayer thanking God for all the artists and curators who are generously sharing so much right now to help others. Pray for the powerful connections we can have through Jesus to help one another despite our physical distance. Invite teens to share or name those they want to pray for, and then close your prayer time.

High School Option

Consider using the Middle School option. Or say: “We’re going to draw ourselves as warriors. Think about what you might be wearing and what tools or weapons you might have. Do you have a mask? armor?” After several minutes, invite teens to share by holding their drawing up to their camera and explaining briefly what their drawing represents. Remind teens that in a way they are like warriors right now.

Ask teens to open their Bible or Bible app to Luke 17:11-19 and to read silently. Use the questions and commentary in Teacher Bible Prep to discuss how powerful Jesus was then and is today. Encourage teens to draw hope from art, music, photos, the natural world, and more during this time. Encourage them to express themselves and their emotions or thoughts in a variety of ways. Share the following link/page so that teens can continue to get ideas for expressing themselves creatively: <https://www.expressiveartworkshops.com/expressive-art-resources/100-art-therapy-exercises>. Take time to close in prayer together.

TAKE AWAY

The arts often are considered secondary or optional behind STEM courses and sports. But this time of sheltering in place has helped reveal how vital the arts are for our overall well-being.

WORKING IT OUT

REWRITE THE WORDS



Use the space to rewrite the words/verses of Psalm 96 to create lyrics for a new song.

In the Bible: Readings for the Week

MONDAY: Read Joshua 4:1-9.

What important event was commemorated with 12 stones?

TUESDAY: Read Exodus 24:1-4.

This monument was built just before what important event?

WEDNESDAY: Read Psalm 23.

How many different sung versions can you find of this psalm?

THURSDAY: Isaiah 6:1-8.

How are you making yourself available to God's call?

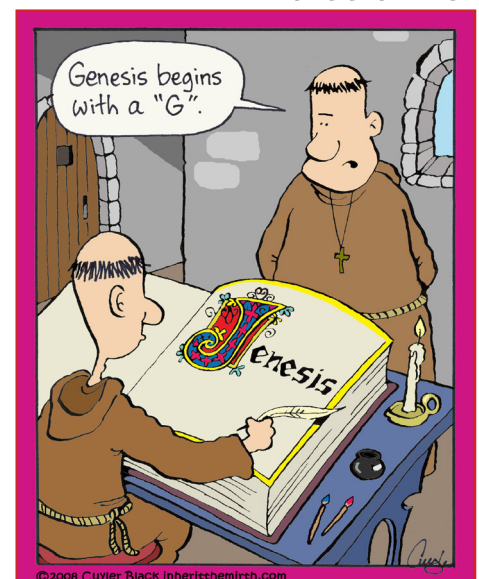
FRIDAY: Read Exodus 35.

How many kinds of arts were involved in creating the meeting tent for God?

SATURDAY: Read Genesis 9:17.

What are some other famous faith symbols, and how have they been portrayed through art?

Inherit the Mirth



WHAT'S TRENDING?

What's your favorite form of creative expression? Tweet or post your response with the hashtag #artsy on Twitter to @YMPartners or on facebook.com/youthministrypartners